GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

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1. GAME OVERVIEW

1.1 Title (Working)
UNNAMED PROJECT

1.2 Genre
Narrative puzzle game with mystery, meta-game elements, and light action.

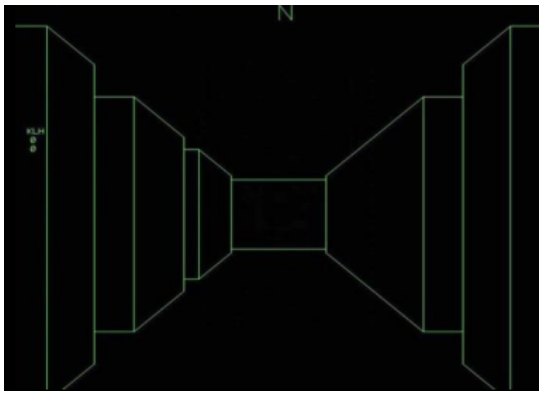
1.3 Platform
PC

1.4 Target Audience
Players interested in surreal tech horror, retro computer aesthetics, puzzle-solving, and meta-narratives involving player-system interaction.

2. SETTING & NARRATIVE

2.1 Setting
- Primary Location: Computer Lab
- Secondary Location: Internal computer layers
- Time Period: 1980s

Primary



Secondary

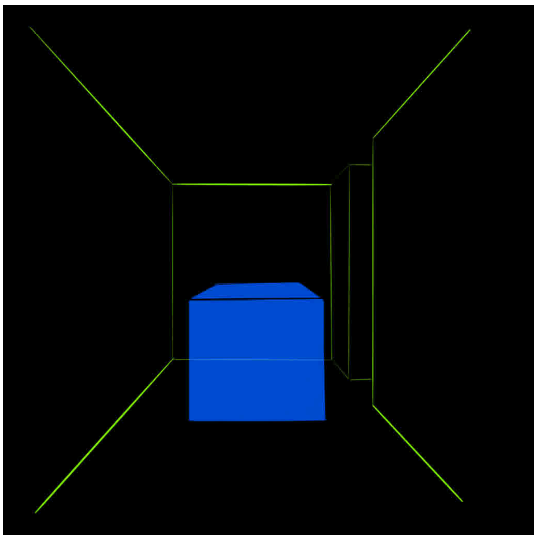
2.2 Story
A scientist unintentionally creates a self aware digital virus while experimenting on an old computer system. The virus navigates internal system layers while uncovering fragmented documents tied to a secret organization. These documents hint at illegal experiments and long-term objectives. The virus ultimately escapes the system by integrating itself into an artificial biological creature.

2.3 Characters

Main Characters
- Dr. D. Hemmington (Scientist)
- Virus Cube (Player-controlled entity)
- Shadow Avatars

Enemies
- Antivirus Programs
- Artificial Creature
- Secret Organization (Indirect presence)

Scientist



Virus Cube

Shadow Avatars

Antivirus Programs (just cubes but yellow)

Artificial Creature in Cage

Secret Organization Symbol

3. GAME LOGIC

3.1 Core Loop

Explore corridors → Discover secrets → Enter mini-game → Acquire item → Return to corridors → Repeat → Final escape sequence

3.2 Perspective Switching

- First-person scientist perspective
- Virus cube perspective
- Mini-game avatar perspective

4. GAMEPLAY SYSTEMS

4.1 Scientist Phase

Description

The player controls the scientist from a seated first-person perspective inside the laboratory.

Mechanics

- Mouse movement: Look around
- Left click: Inspect objects (rotatable inspection view)
- Interacting with monitor locks camera and zooms in
- Escape key zooms out and opens contextual pause/menu state

Purpose

- Environmental storytelling
- Puzzle discovery

Security Escalation System

Trigger

Scientist intervention after mini-game disruptions.

Mechanics

- Scientist says his lines and game switches its focus from the computer
- Scientist automatically selects the keyboard
- Player must input a directional/button code to proceed
- Example input: ← ↑ A ↓ → B ← ↓
- Introduction of additional hazards (laser timing obstacles)

4.2 Virus Cube Phase

Description
Player controls a digital virus navigating abstract corridors inside the computer system.

Controls
- Arrow Keys: Movement
- Spacebar: Interaction

Mechanics
- Corridor navigation
- Environmental interaction (documents, photos, audio logs)
- Door spawning after a fixed number of turns

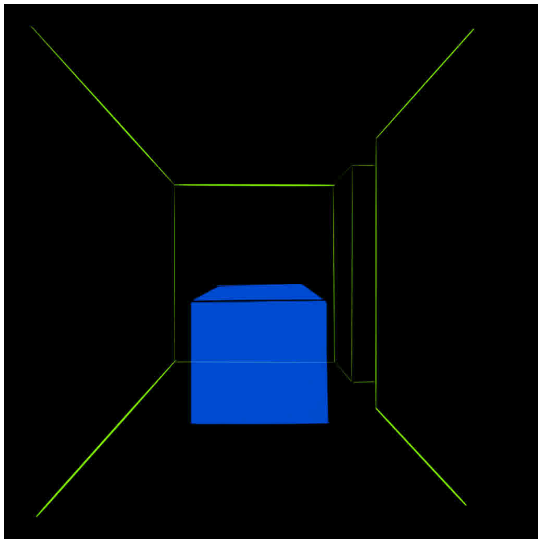
Failure State
- Contact with antivirus or lazers displays a dead screen and resets the section.

Exit Room System

Description
A room encountered between corridor sections.

Components
- Exit device
- Three item slots

Function
- Acts as a hub and progression gate
- Requires items or data from mini-games to activate exit



5. MINI-GAMES

Description

Each mini-game exists as a window inside the desktop environment and uses a distinct gameplay genre.

Common Rules

- Completion grants a key item or critical information
- UI instability increases after each completion
- System glitches force return to corridor phase

5.1 Mini-Game 1: Isometric Adventure

Genre Reference

1984-era isometric action-adventure, inspired by **Knight Lore** and early Ultima titles.

Presentation

- Fixed isometric perspective
- Flat-shaded tiles with strict grid alignment
- Limited color palette with harsh contrast
- Character and objects rendered as simple geometric sprites

Player Representation

A humanoid figure rendered as an abstract armored sprite.

- A knight-like silhouette

Controls

- Arrow Keys: Movement relative to the isometric grid
- Space Key: Interact, pick up objects, activate mechanisms

Core Mechanics

- Single-screen isometric room navigation
- Environmental puzzle-solving through object placement
- Item pickup and stacking to access higher elevations

All objects has strict height, collision, and layering rules.

Objective

- Completing simple puzzle platforms
- Mixing all materials to make a potion

-Rooms-

Storage Room
- Used for holding supplies and discarded objects.
- Contains crates and heavy blocks
- Elevated shelf or platform
- Potion ingredient stored out of reach

Purpose: basic height puzzle using stacked objects.

Collapsed Passage
- A broken corridor section.
- Large gap where floor has fallen away
- Debris usable as makeshift bridges
- Potion ingredient on the far side

Purpose: gap-crossing with planks and pillars.

Service Corridor
- A narrow maintenance hallway.
- Sloped floor and uneven ground
- Barrels stored along the wall
- Raised service platform with ingredient

Purpose: ramp-based elevation puzzle.

Central Chamber

Description
A square chamber acting as the central hub of the dungeon. Three corridors lead to nearby puzzle rooms. There is a big cauldron filled with water in the middle of the room and a hooded wizard stands beside the cauldron. On first interaction, he says: “The ingredients are scattered nearby. Bring them here.”

Progression
- Each connected room contains one ingredient
- Upon returning an ingredient, wizard gives a key to open the next room
- When ingredients got added into the mix, the color changes

Completion
Wizard casts a magic to finish the potion and he hands the potion to the player.

5.2 Mini-Game 2: Text-Based Adventure

Genre Reference
Classic text adventure, ZORK-style interaction.

Presentation
- Monochrome text on black background
- Blinking cursor
- Typed input numbers to choose what to do
- Once the option displays all the content it has, greys out

Hidden States
HasSpokenToFigure, HasLookedAround, HasArguedBard
All are false by default and affect certain dialogue variations.

Initial Setting Output
Rain pours down, and you decide to take shelter in the nearest building. A sign beside a large door reads: "Sandy's Tavern?" The first thing you notice is the smell. Old wood, lingering regrets, and a dead mouse. The next thing is somehow worse. A bard screams into a flute, producing something that feels less like music and more like an ear infection. You briefly wonder if your other senses have failed you, then decide to use your eyes. An innkeeper stands behind the counter, polishing a mug with a rag that has clearly seen better days.

Scene 0
What do you want to do?

- ASK FOR DRINK -> A
- LOOK AROUND -> B
- TALK TO FIGURE -> C
- ASK BARD TO STOP -> D

if HasSpokenToFigure true

- LOOK AT THE CAT -> E

Scene A
The Innkeeper wipes the counter. "Uhh, are you gonna order? This place is not a shelter for scumbags like you. You guys even fucking stole my ladle! I was using that to bonk some unholy folk and sometimes for mixing things. If you can bring it back to me, you can pick any drink for free. I think the culprit is still here by the way. Be quick!"
Return 0

Scene B
You scanned the enviroment quickly, the things you saw:
A cat jumping ropes.
A knight in full armor.
A person who talks backwards.
– *HasLookedAround* sets true –
Return 0

Scene C

You get close to the mysterious person. He notices you and says: Answer me this riddle, if you can: What has keys but cannot open doors? .. .. Oh I didn't thought for you to be this dumb. Just tell me something weird you saw today.

if HasLookedAround is true

- KNIGHT IN ARMOR -> "Boring asf"
- SOMEONE WHO TALKS BACKWARDS -> "Thats just Gary"

Return C

- A CAT JUMPING ROPES -> "Holy shit. Thats the clue you wanted. Follow the leads."

HasSpokenToFigure sets true, Return 0

if HasLookedAround is false

- INNKEEPER? -> "Hey! He is my cousin."
- FUCKING BARD? -> "Its not something unusual. I kinda got deaf after that dudes music."
- IDK, YOU? -> "Fuck you!"

Return 0

Scene D

You warned the bard. His response: SHUT DA HELL UP YOU NON-BRAINCELL, UNSIGNIFICANT FUCK. Return 0 HasArguedBard sets true

Scene E

The cat's legs got tangled to the rope. You wanted to help but unfortunately you frightened the cat. Suddenly that cute thing got triggered from bard's 'music' and begin to attack him.
"AAAAAAAAAAAA"

Bard said: Okay man just chill.. Seems like no one likes my music. I gave up. Just take this ladle and dont ask questions..
You Got x1 Golden Ladle!
Its a bit warm, you decided to not question it furthermore.

Completion

- Simply game crashes

5.3 Mini-Game 3: Top-Down Racing

Genre Reference
Early 1980s arcade-style racing games.

Presentation
- Fixed top-down camera
- Limited color palette
- HUD displaying speed and remaining time

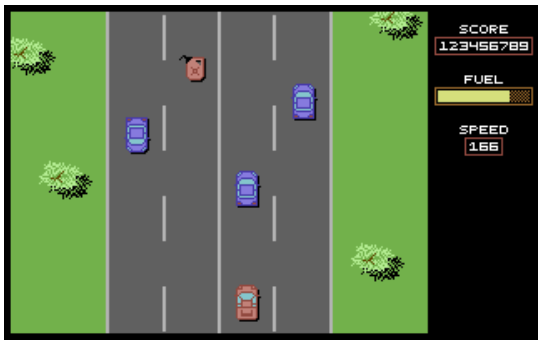
Controls
- Left / Right: Steering
- Up: Accelerate
- Down: Brake

Core Mechanics
- Constant forward-scrolling track
- Obstacle avoidance (traffic, barriers, oil slicks)

Objective
Reach the end of the track within the time limit.

Failure State
- Collision resets vehicle to the starting point

Reward
- Traffic cone



5.4 Terminal Login Puzzle

Description
Player must log into the computer using a binary-based password system.

Mechanics
- Six togglable binary digits displayed as 0s and 1s
- Password clue hidden behind a photograph of the scientist's deceased wife
- Password value: 38
- Correct binary input: 100110

Result
- Binary digits collapse into a cube
- Cube becomes the controllable entity

6. LEVEL STRUCTURE

6.1 Laboratory

Asset list:

- Monitor
- Chair
- Desk
- Landline Phone
- Photo Frame
- Keyboard
- Mouse
- Mug
- Curtains
- Windows
- Lamp
- Ceiling Fan
- Cables

6.2 Corridor Layer Point A

Asset list:

- Cube
- Walls
- Gate

6.3 Exit Room

Asset list:

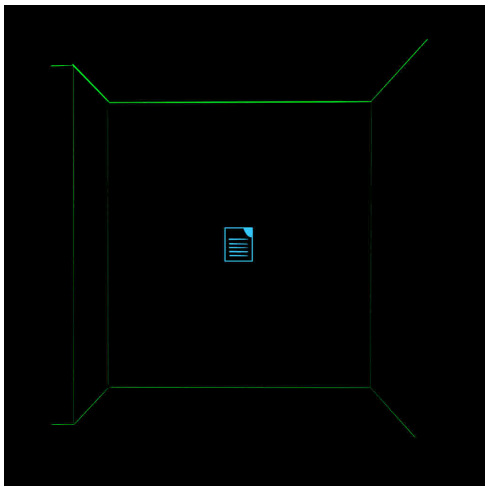
- Slot
- Cables
- Exit Gate
- Shadow Avatar Room Entrance Gate
- Shadow Avatar

6.4 Mini-Game 1 (Platforming)

6.5 Corridor Layer Point B (Document)

Asset list:

- Cube
- Walls
- Gate
- Lazers
- Document



Content of the document:

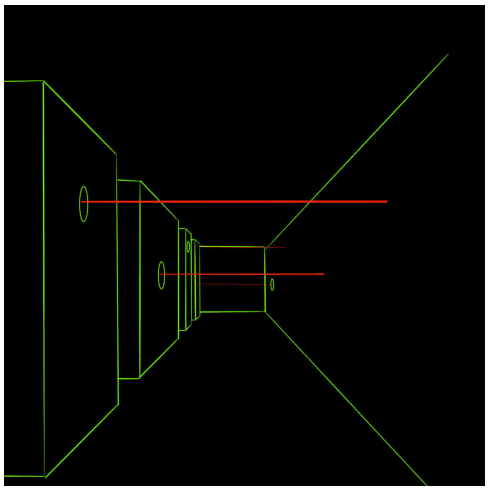
```
This is agent A47… I have been trying to
breach the target multiple times and
aborted it due to the high level security
network  , although good news is We have
intel on how to awaken the Artificial
creature ACB66 , the only way to do it
would be to )@(&&(&(&;&;€€#££^€{££€£#^€¥¥
++%%#+message corrupted Please inform the
Board that they need to reach his network
if they want to get their hands on it
now , rest of the message is corrupted.
```

6.6 Mini-Game 2 (Text Adventure)

6.7 Corridor Layer Point C (Photo)

Asset list:

- Cube
- Walls
- Gate
- Lazers
- Anti-Viruses
- Photo



6.8 Mini-Game 3 (Racing)

6.9 Corridor Layer Point D (Voice Message)

Asset list:

- Cube
- Walls
- Gate
- Photo
- Voice Message

7. HUD DESIGN

7.1 Scientist Phase HUD

```
> No persistent HUD elements.
```

The scientist phase is fully diegetic. All information is communicated through the environment itself.

- **Monitor glow** indicates the computer is active and awaiting interaction
- **Phone light** pulses when a call is incoming
- **Desk objects** serve as implicit checklists — player learns to read the room
- Security escalation state is communicated through the scientist's dialogue and posture, not a status bar
- Input prompt for the directional code appears as text printed on the monitor screen, not as an overlay

7.2 Virus Cube Phase HUD

```
> SYSTEM STATUS: NOMINAL
```

All HUD elements are rendered as glitchy terminal overlays that feel native to the digital environment.

Elements

- **Turn Counter** — bottom left, monospace digits, displayed as:

  ```
  > MOVES: 0042
  ```

  Counts total moves taken in the current corridor. No explicit limit shown — tension is implied, not quantified.

- **Item Slots** — bottom right, three bracketed cells mirroring the Exit Room slots:

  ```
  > [ITEM_A] [——] [——]
  ```

  Empty slots show dashes. Acquired items display a short tag. Slots pulse green briefly on pickup.

- **Threat Indicator** — top right, only appears when an antivirus is within three tiles:

  ```
  > ! INTRUDER DETECTED
  ```

  Fades out when threat clears. No minimap — the player must navigate by feel.

- **Glitch Meter** — represented not as a bar but as increasing visual corruption on the HUD itself. After each mini-game completion, terminal text begins to flicker, characters drop out, and scanlines thicken. The HUD degrading **is** the meter.

7.3 Mini-Game HUDs

MG 1 — Isometric Adventure

- No HUD overlay. Inventory is shown as physical objects carried by the player sprite.
- Ingredient count is communicated by the wizard's dialogue only.

MG 2 — Text Adventure

- Pure text interface. No HUD elements outside the terminal output itself.
- Hidden states are never surfaced to the player visually.

MG 3 — Top-Down Racing

- Minimal overlay in the style of an arcade cabinet bezel:

```
> SPD: 088 TIME: 01:24
```

  Speed and remaining time only. Both flash red when time drops below 15 seconds.

Terminal Login Puzzle

- The six binary digits are the only UI. No instructions displayed — the password clue on the photograph is the only affordance.

8. AUDIO DESIGN

8.1 Design Philosophy

Audio serves as the primary indicator of system state. The world is unreliable visually — audio should feel slightly more grounded, then betray the player at key moments. All sound design targets the feeling of a machine that is barely holding together.

8.2 Ambient Layers

Laboratory

- Low electrical hum
- Ceiling fan
- Distant street noise through window (muffled)
- CRT monitor static hiss, audible only when close

Corridors

- Pitch shifts slightly each corridor
- Faint data transmission noise (arrhythmic clicks and bursts)
- Silence used deliberately in dead-end paths

Exit Room

- Tone shifts to a lower, more resonant hum
- Subtle heartbeat-like pulse tied to how many slots are filled

8.3 Interaction Sounds

Scientist Phase

- Object pickup: soft mechanical click
- Inspection mode entry/exit: camera shutter
- Monitor interaction: CRT power-on whine
- Directional code input: each keypress is a distinct retro beep, sequence plays a short jingle on success, harsh buzz on failure
- Phone ring: authentic 1980s bell ring, attenuated through room reverb

Virus Cube Phase

- Item pickup: ascending three-note chime (8-bit register)
- Document/photo discovery: paper rustle layered under a data-read beep
- Antivirus proximity: high-frequency interference that grows louder and more distorted as threat closes in
- Death: hard digital cut to silence, then CRT static burst before reset

8.4 Mini-Game Audio

Mini-Game 1 — Isometric Adventure

- Medieval-adjacent synth score
- Object placement: wooden thock sound with slight reverb
- Wizard speech: no voice acting — text appears with a low “bwom” per word

Mini-Game 2 — Text Adventure

- Near silence. Only ambient: faint tavern murmur, indistinct
- Bard’s flute: deliberately atonal and bad, loops in background until Scene D or E resolves it
- Each typed option selection: mechanical typewriter clack

- Game crash completion: audio cuts entirely before returning to corridor

Mini-Game 3 — Top-Down Racing
- Upbeat retro synth track, faster BPM than other sections
- Engine sound: synthesized, pitch-shifts with speed value
- Collision: short noise burst, engine sound cuts and restarts
- Time warning (under 15s): metronome tick added over music

Terminal Login Puzzle
- Each binary toggle: low beep (0) / high beep (1)
- Correct input sequence: the six tones play back as a melody

8.5 Music System

Tracks
- **LAB_THEME** — slow, unresolved ambient synth. Plays during scientist phase.
- **CORRIDOR_THEME** — generative drone with arrhythmic percussion layer.
- **EXITROOM_THEME** — variant of CORRIDOR_THEME, lower register, more tense.
- **MINIGAME_1_THEME** — medieval synth loop, 90 BPM.
- **MINIGAME_2_THEME** — near-silent. Tavern murmur only.
- **MINIGAME_3_THEME** — arcade racing loop, 140 BPM.

Transitions
All music transitions use a 1.5 second crossfade except:
- Corridor ⟶ Death: hard cut
- Mini-game completion ⟶ Corridor: audio glitch effect bridges the transition

Spatial Audio
- Laboratory: full 3D spatial audio on all objects
- Corridors: 2D audio for HUD sounds, 3D for antivirus and collectibles
- Mini-games: all 2D — treat as separate audio context

9. ART DIRECTION

9.1 Visual Style

- Retro 1980s computer aesthetic
- CRT distortion effects
- Neon wireframe corridors
- Low-resolution interfaces
- Glitch overlays

9.2 Creature Design

- Organic, slimy artificial creature
- Strong contrast between digital and biological forms